

transfer is saved by automation, and they can instead focus on their core jobs. The FTE (full-time equivalent), which is the number of working hours of an employee in a fixed period of time, can be adjusted to incorporate the added productivity from the returned work hours. RPA also does away with factors such as the use of IT resources and training costs. When automation reduces the tiring work of employees, it increases work satisfaction, which means reduced staff turnover and better productivity.

In case an employee is on leave or there is a request overload, it leads to downtime when ideally the service should have been available. The improvement due to the shortening of queues, service availability, and customer satisfaction can be estimated and added for ROI calculation.

Doing away with manual errors means a reduced need for cross-checking and reducing the number of redos for a task. Depending on the error rate of a process, you can add that into the estimation too.

On the flip side, RPA doesn't come for free. So, consider the costs involved during and after deployment.

For the cost of RPA, first, consider the license cost of the tool. If the process is dynamic, more bots will be needed, and hence the cost will be higher.

Then consider the cost of infrastructure required for deployment after consulting the IT department—servers, test environment, and so on.

Add the potential cost of development, taking into consideration as many factors as possible over time. Based on the complexity of an individual process (low, medium, or high), the average development time and expenditure will differ. Whether a company decides to partially or fully outsource the development—training or hiring experts, running the automation tests, etc—will change the cost substantially. With experience over time, the teams will perform better than they did initially.

Finally, the maintenance and monitoring costs come into play when there are issues in the additional infrastructure, changes in business process needs, exceptions encountered, or as a result of any other unexpected outcome. The subscription-based cost of an RPA tool includes maintenance

issues related to the tool itself, but these problems are not covered in it.

If this sounds like a lot of work, there are numerous ROI calculators available online to help you with the estimation. Depending on the delivery model, the ROI may vary, but the time period is always shorter as compared to other forms of IT automation. Faster ROI, sometimes even a few weeks for a single process, is one of the main reasons why companies are willing to go for RPA. According to McKinsey, they noticed that the ROI varied between 30 and 200 per cent in the first year across sixteen of their case studies. Numerous vendors offer free trials and even cloud RPA as a service for greater benefit.

Choosing the right tool

There is no single right tool for a particular type of business. It just depends on your needs, the ability of the tool to integrate with existing systems, and the costs incurred. As mentioned earlier, the total cost includes the setup cost, license fees, and the maintenance cost for the tool.

It is good to check if your preferred vendor has successfully deployed bots in a company in the past that had similar pain points and was similar in terms of size. Also, read the terms and conditions for maintenance and support and ensure that your requirements are met.

The chosen tool must be platform-independent and able to support different types of applications. It should have a user-friendly interface so that employees can get used to it easily, and there are no hassles in learning. RPA tools can be prone to attacks if proper security measures are not in place. Scalability is important for automation to be efficient at a large scale.

The impact

"I remember an industry senior telling me how the RPA market size will grow in the coming years during my college days. While many fear that it will replace humans, experts believe that RPA is more likely to alter current job functions and even lead to new job creation. Automation with its present capabilities cannot be a substitute for problem solving and interactions that only humans can perform. Although the fact that employees will need to

upskill and reskill to fit in the dynamic job roles cannot be denied," says Sirisha.

Sirisha further says, "Whenever we speak about new technology, it is critical to ensure the employees are upskilled adequately for it, and the change is celebrated in organisational culture. Employees handling processes starting from the warehouse's material movement until the technology-intensive process like testing need to be upskilled and gain know-how about using the automated processes, which helps save time. For example, engineers handling tasks like total productive maintenance and analysis understood the new infrastructure and adapted themselves to new maintenance and defect analysis workflow."

Manish says, "With the onset of the pandemic, we have also seen a large uptake from governments as well. For example, EY India with UiPath developed an RPA solution for the Municipal Corporation of Greater Mumbai to generate bulk e-passes for service aggregators supplying essential supplies and services to residents of Mumbai during the lockdown. This helped relieve their manual team from investing tremendous efforts in mundane, time-consuming tasks."

While employees' workstyle will definitely change with automation, on the technical front, RPA, just like any other technology, is prone to cyberattacks. This can lead to a data breach. But if proper measures are implemented, it can rather serve as an asset.

"Technology is a boon when used in the right manner. It can be and should be used to make our lives easier and safer. Cybersecurity is becoming predominantly crucial in the production environment of various processes like the end of line stations, test stations, etc, where data security is essential. At the manufacturing unit, the level of standardising cybersecurity systems is key to successful deployment," adds Sirisha.

RPA architecture needs to have multiple protection layers, so that the RPA tools won't open a suspicious link. This reduces the chances of human-centered attacks as the access to authorised information is with RPA. Proper monitoring and alerts can keep the users updated in case there is an intrusion. **EFY**